TAMIL NADU'S RESPONSIBLE TOURISM INITIATIVES

Tamil Nadu is answering the call of the future by taking a slew of steps towards promoting responsible tourism in the state

Recognising the fact that responsible tourism is the need of the hour, Tamil Nadu is employing a multi-pronged strategy to promote it in the state. Initiatives include developing new destinations to decongest mass tourism locations, promoting a variety of eco-tourism friendly types of tourism, installation of solar panels in government-run hotels, sensitising travellers to be responsible, and much more.

Tamil Nadu's Draft Tourism Policy envisages tourism development at destinations that facilitate economic, social and environmental sustainability. One of the key strategic objectives of the policy is to increase the economic value of the existing tourism ecosystem with balance and sustainability. The Department of Tourism is also working towards decongesting mass tourism locations through the development and promotion of lesser-known destinations like Kolli Hills, Jawadhu Hills, Muthupettai Mangrove Forest, and so on. Aiming to improve visitor experiences at destinations, the Tourism Destination Development Scheme was launched to identify and develop tourist attractions in the state in accordance with the concepts of integrated and sustainable development.

A major achievement has been the Blue Flag certification that Kovalam (aka Covelong) Beach received in September 2021. The globally recognised certification was awarded by the Denmark-based Foundation for Environment Education. The eco-friendly beach is run by TTDC and, besides its cleanliness, offers a variety of facilities for visitors, including a safe bathing area with lifeguards, clean drinking water, swimming options for the disabled, green cover and so on.

TTDC also runs over 50 properties across Tamil Nadu so any of its initiatives has a large and direct impact on tourism. In a major move towards reducing its carbon footprint, TTDC is installing solar panels across its hotels. The properties also provide employment for local communities, a hallmark of responsible tourism.

The Department of Tourism is also facilitating the development of different forms of tourism that cause minimal impact to the natural environment. These include adventure tourism, caravan tourism and camping. Promotion of niche forms of tourism like coastal tourism, which enables local community involvement, is underway.

Several other initiatives are also in the pipeline. TTDC is in the process of developing caravan parks in two locations in Tamil Nadu. There is a plan to develop the Nilgiris as a Special Ecological Zone. Feasibility studies for the development of sustainable destinations like Kolli Hills and Mannavanur are being carried out. Besides, segments like plantation tourism which have a low impact on the environment are being prioritised.

Given the humongous effort Tamil Nadu is putting into responsible tourism, it will soon emerge as the leading responsible tourism destination in India.







